

SHAME WORDSshame
contritionculpability
discomposureembarrassment
humiliationmortification
self-conscious

shyness

Prompting Events for Feeling Shame

- Being rejected by people you care about.
- Having others find out that you have done something wrong.
- Doing (or feeling or thinking) something that people you admire believe is wrong or immoral.
- Comparing some aspect of yourself or your behavior to a standard and feeling as if you do not live up to that standard.
- Being betrayed by a person you love.
- Being laughed at/made fun of.
- Being criticized in public/in front of someone else; remembering public criticism.
- Others attacking your integrity.
- Being reminded of something wrong, immoral, or “shameful” you did in the past.
- Being rejected or criticized for something you expected praise for.
- Having emotions/experiences that have been invalidated.
- Exposure of a very private aspect of yourself or your life.
- Exposure of a physical characteristic you dislike.
- Failing at something you feel you are (or should be) competent to do.
- Other: _____

Interpretations of Events That Prompt Feelings of Shame

- Believing that others will reject you (or have rejected you).
- Judging yourself to be inferior, not “good enough,” not as good as others; self-invalidation.
- Comparing yourself to others and thinking that you are a “loser.”
- Believing yourself unlovable.
- Thinking that you are bad, immoral, or wrong.
- Thinking that you are defective.
- Thinking that you are a bad person or a failure.
- Believing your body (or a body part) is too big, too small, or ugly.
- Thinking that you have not lived up to others’ expectations of you.
- Thinking that your behavior, thoughts, or feelings are silly or stupid.
- Other: _____

Biological Changes and Experiences of Shame

- Pain in the pit of the stomach.
- Sense of dread.
- Wanting to shrink down and/or disappear.
- Wanting to hide or cover your face and body.
- Other: _____

Expressions and Actions of Shame

- Hiding behavior or a characteristic from other people.
- Avoiding the person you have harmed.
- Avoiding persons who have criticized you.
- Avoiding yourself—distracting, ignoring.
- Withdrawing; covering the face.
- Bowing your head, groveling.
- Appeasing; saying you are sorry over and over and over.
- Looking down and away from others.
- Sinking back; slumped and rigid posture.
- Halting speech; lowered volume while talking.
- Other: _____

Aftereffects of Shame

- Avoiding thinking about your transgression; shutting down; blocking all emotions.
- Engaging in distracting, impulsive behaviors to divert your mind or attention.
- High amount of “self-focus”; preoccupation with yourself.
- Depersonalization, dissociative experiences, numbness, or shock.
- Attacking or blaming others.
- Conflicts with other people.
- Isolation, feeling alienated.
- Impairment in problem-solving ability.
- Other: _____

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